

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN GREENLAND

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Greenland's distinctive lever — self-government at an intimate scale, where a self-ruling Arctic nation of some fifty-six thousand controls its own mineral resources, a town of a thousand can shape a national election, and a single project can decide who governs — and it names the tools you'll meet (the Inatsisartut and Naalakkersuisut, the consultation and environmental process, the courts, and the democratic and legislative power of a self-governing people) in plain words.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Just eight kilometres from **Narsaq** — a close-knit community of about a thousand people who live by fishing, sheep farming, and the harvest of the land and sea — lay **Kuannersuit**, known in Danish as **Kvanefjeld**: one of the world's greatest deposits of rare-earth metals, the elements that drive electric motors, wind turbines, and weapons. But the ore was laced with **uranium and thorium**, and to mine it meant risking radioactive dust and waste in a fragile Arctic where nothing washes clean. The Australian company that held it, backed by a Chinese partner, had sunk more than a hundred million dollars into it and was, under the government of the day, on track for final approval. The people of Narsaq had feared it for years — "we rely on the land and the sea," as one put it, and "uranium dust would destroy everything we depend on." So they made their fear the country's decision. When Greenland went to the polls in **April 2021**, the mine was the question on the ballot in all but name, and the party that promised to stop it, **Inuit Ataqatigiit**, won. That **November, the parliament passed a law banning uranium mining** — and because the law barred mining any deposit above a hundred parts per million, while Kvanefjeld's ore ran at roughly three hundred, it did not merely pause the project; it **closed it**. A town of a thousand, using a nation's democracy, had stopped a mine the whole world wanted.

The people of Narsaq made their fear the country's decision — and the distinctive lever they used is self-government at an intimate scale. Greenland's own **parliament (the Inatsisartut)** and **government (the Naalakkersuisut)** control its mineral resources, and can be shaped by an election a single project can decide, as the April 2021 vote decided Kvanefjeld. The **consultation and environmental process** governs a project. The **courts** are open. The **land-and-sea livelihoods** that bind Greenlanders to their environment are a powerful, unifying stake. And a community's voice, at this intimate scale — a town of a thousand shaping a national election — can move a nation; protest, petition, and democratic mobilisation are the tools. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Greenland depends heavily on an annual **block grant from Denmark**, and many Greenlanders see mining revenue as the path to the **economic independence** they long for — so there is a powerful, standing pressure for large projects, and the anti-uranium victory ran against that current, not with it (only eight years earlier, the same parliament had lifted a decades-old ban on mining radioactive materials to court that revenue). The company did not simply walk away: it pursued **compensation through international arbitration**, a claim reported in the billions. And Greenland's rare earths sit at the centre of a **great-power contest** — China, the United States, and Europe all covet them — so a local decision can draw pressures far larger than the fjord it concerns. So aim for what this lever can deliver, reckoning honestly with the money, the independence dream, and the geopolitics it must face.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A world-coveted mine looks unstoppable, but at Greenland's intimate scale a single project can decide an election and a law, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Greenlandic fight turns on the **democratic power** to make a project the ballot question; on the **legislative power** of the Inatsisartut to change the law; on the **consultation and environmental process**; on the **courts**; and on the **land-and-sea livelihoods** that bind a community. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and the democratic-and-legislative power of a self-governing people is the one that closed Kvanefjeld. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months on this, work out your real situation:

- **If a project can be made the country's decision, self-government is your sharpest lever** — at Greenland's scale, a town of a thousand shaped an election and closed a mine.
- **If it threatens land-and-sea livelihoods, that stake unifies** — "we rely on the land and the sea" was Narsaq's cause.
- **If the law can be changed, the Inatsisartut can do it** — the uranium ban didn't pause Kvanefjeld, it closed it.
- **If economic-independence pressure runs for the project, know you're going against the current** — the anti-uranium win ran against the establishment's own policy, so build the case and the coalition to reverse it.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **make a project the country's democratic decision, and change the law through the Inatsisartut**, and **reckon honestly with the independence dream, the money, and the geopolitics** that run for big projects. That's how Narsaq closed Kvanefjeld.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

Greenland's **Naalakkersuisut (government)** and **Inatsisartut (parliament)** control the mineral resources and grant the approvals — and both can be shaped by an election a single project can decide. The **consultation and environmental process** governs a project. The **courts** are open. And behind it all runs the standing pressure of the **economic-independence** dream and the block grant, and the pull of **great-power** interest. Know which of these you can reach — the democratic and legislative power of a self-governing people is the sharpest.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The approval and the environmental process. The government moves toward approval through consultation and environmental review. *Your opening:* the consultation and the environmental risks — the radioactive dust, the fragile Arctic.

The election. *Your opening — the decisive one:* make the project the ballot question, as Narsaq did, so a government that would stop it wins.

The legislation. *Your opening:* the Inatsisartut can change the law to close a project, as the uranium ban closed Kvanefjeld.

The courts. *Your opening:* a flawed process or approval, challengeable in the courts.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who finances it** — the foreign company and its partners, and whether an investor-state claim looms. **What it risks** — the radioactive dust, the fragile Arctic, the land-and-sea livelihoods — your unifying stake. **What current runs for it** — the economic-independence dream, the block grant, the great-power interest — because you may be going against it, and must build to reverse it.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **Naalakkersuisut and Inatsisartut** control the minerals and can be shaped and moved. The **consultation and environmental process** checks a project. The **courts** review it. And Greenland's **affected communities, the wider public, and international allies** are the forces that reach furthest — the intimate-scale democracy that closed a world-coveted mine.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether a project can be made the country's decision, whether livelihoods unify the public, and how strongly the independence-and-money current runs for it.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Raise the environmental / livelihood case	25–50%	months–yr	low	The unifying stake established
Object in the consultation	15–35%	during process	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Make it the ballot question	35–60%	election cycle	low	A government that will stop it wins
Change the law (Inatsisartut)	35–60%	months–yr	low	A project closed by legislation (Kvanefjeld)
Court challenge (flawed process)	25–50%	months–yr	mod	Approval or process quashed
Public mobilisation	30–55%	months–yr	low	A national cause; a decision
Everything together (democracy + legislation)	40–65%	election cycle+	mod	Project stopped, law changed
Against the independence-and-money current	20–45%	years	low	A reversal won against the establishment

The levers that move the needle most are the **democratic power** to make a project the ballot question and the **legislative power** of the Inatsisartut, backed by the **land-and-sea livelihoods** and public mobilisation. Kvanefjeld shows the ceiling (a town of a thousand closing a world-coveted mine by an election and a law)

and the honest floor (it ran against the independence-and-money current, and the company pursued a billion-dollar arbitration). So aim for a project stopped, a livelihood defended, and a law changed — reckoning with the current you go against.

On cost: raising the livelihood case, objecting, making a project the ballot question, and mobilising cost mainly organised effort; litigation costs more; the arbitration risk falls on the government, not the community. The great strength is self-government at an intimate scale; the great requirement is to build the case and coalition to reverse a current — money, independence, geopolitics — that often runs for big projects.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the mine" is weak. Being specific — this radioactive risk, this livelihood, this ballot question — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the foreign company and its partners, and whether an investor-state claim could loom.

2. What does it risk? The **radioactive dust, the pollution, the fragile Arctic, and the land-and-sea livelihoods** — the livelihood stake is your sharpest, most unifying lever, as at Narsaq.

3. Can it be made the country's decision? Whether, at Greenland's intimate scale, the project can become **the ballot question**, so a government that would stop it wins — the decisive Kvanefjeld move.

4. What stage is it at, and what's the opening? Is the consultation or environmental process open? Is an election coming (make it the question)? Can the Inatsisartut change the law? These are the openings.

5. Who's your coalition, and what current runs for it? The **affected community, the wider public, and international allies** — and an honest read of the **economic-independence and great-power current** you may be going against.

What this looks like in real life. A world-coveted mine, laced with radioactive material, threatens a small town's land and sea, on track for approval. The five questions yield: the foreign company and its partners; the radioactive risk and the livelihoods (your unifying lever); a project that can be made the ballot question; a consultation, an election, and a legislative opening; and a coalition going against the independence-and-money current. That's the Narsaq pattern — make the project the country's decision, change the law through the Inatsisartut, and build to reverse the current.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof — of the risk to the land and sea. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the environmental and livelihood risk. The heart of it: document the **radioactive dust and waste, the pollution, the harm to the fragile Arctic, and the threat to the land-and-sea livelihoods** — the fishing, the farming, the harvest — with evidence and testimony. "Uranium dust would destroy everything we depend on" was Narsaq's case.

Layer two: the process and the paper trail. Get the **consultation record, the environmental assessment, and the approvals**, and read them for the flaws and the understated risks.

Layer three: the political map. Map the **electoral and legislative opening** — whether the project can be made the ballot question and the law changed — and the **current** that runs for it (independence, money, geopolitics). Walking into the consultation, the election, the Inatsisartut, or the courts with the documented risk and that political map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The environmental and livelihood risk** — the radioactive dust, the pollution, the harm to fishing and farming — with evidence and testimony.
- **The consultation record, environmental assessment, and approvals** — from the Naalakkersuisut and the process.
- **The electoral and legislative opening** — can it be the ballot question? can the law be changed?
- **The current that runs for it** — the independence dream, the block grant, the great-power interest.
- **Any investor-state exposure** — the arbitration risk the government faces.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a community that makes a project the country's decision gives you the power Narsaq showed. Build in four moves.

Root it in the land-and-sea livelihoods. Narsaq's cause was "we rely on the land and the sea." Root the fight in the fishing, the farming, the harvest — the livelihoods a radioactive mine would destroy, the stake that unifies a community and a nation.

Make it the country's decision. The decisive Kvanefjeld move: make the project **the ballot question**, so a government that would stop it wins. At Greenland's intimate scale, a town of a thousand can do this — build the mobilisation that turns a local fear into a national vote.

Build toward the legislative change. A win at the polls can become a **law** through the Inatsisartut that closes the project, as the uranium ban closed Kvanefjeld. Build toward that legislative goal.

Build to last, against the current. The anti-uranium win ran against the independence-and-money current, and the company pursued arbitration. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, international allies, and the endurance to reverse an established policy and weather the pressures — money, independence, geopolitics.

STEP 4: SELF-GOVERNMENT, LEGISLATION & THE PROCESS

Greenland's sharpest levers are the democratic and legislative power of a self-governing people, at an intimate scale.

Making a Project the Country's Decision — the Decisive Lever

The Kvanefjeld lever: at Greenland's intimate scale, a community can make a project **the ballot question**, so a government that would stop it wins the election. A town of a thousand shaped a national vote and closed a mine the world wanted. This is Greenland's sharpest, most distinctive power.

Legislative Power — the Inatsisartut

A win at the polls can become a **law** through the **Inatsisartut** that closes a project — as the November 2021 uranium ban, barring any deposit above a hundred parts per million, closed Kvanefjeld outright. Build toward the legislative change that makes a win permanent.

The Consultation, the Environmental Process, and the Courts

Use the **consultation and environmental process** to establish the radioactive and livelihood risks and to force conditions or a redo, and the **courts** to challenge a flawed process or approval — the everyday levers that build toward the decisive democratic one.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: self-government is a rare and powerful lever, but the independence-and-money current runs for big projects, the geopolitics are large, and the company may pursue a billion-dollar arbitration against the government. So use the levers — the democratic power to make a project the ballot question, the legislative power of the Inatsisartut, the process, and the courts — build to reverse the current, and count a project stopped, a livelihood defended, and a law changed as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Radioactive risk becomes a livelihood threat. Not "we oppose the mine" but *"uranium dust would destroy the land and sea we live by — everything we depend on."*

A project becomes the country's decision. *"This mine is the choice before the nation — vote for those who will stop it,"* as Narsaq made it.

A win becomes a law. *"Let the Inatsisartut ban mining above this uranium threshold — and close this project for good."*

The current becomes an honest reckoning. *"We long for independence, but not at the cost of poisoning the land and sea we live by — there are better paths to it."*

Match it to the venue: the livelihood risk to the public and the ballot; the ballot question to the election; the legislative change to the Inatsisartut; the process flaws to the consultation and the courts.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Greenland, public opinion is decisive, because at this intimate scale a project can become the ballot question and decide who governs — and international attention reaches the great-power interest and the company's reputation. A free press and a close-knit society make the media front central.

Lead with the land, the sea, and the radioactive risk, not procedure. Not "the assessment was deficient" but "a uranium mine eight kilometres from town, whose dust would destroy the land and sea we live by." Use your strongest material: the radioactive and livelihood risk, and the community's voice.

Work several audiences at once. Greenlandic press and public make the project the country's decision; international attention reaches the great-power contest and the company's reputation, where they're exposed. Make it easy: clear risk evidence, the livelihood stake, strong testimony.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit the case. And honour the independence dream — argue that poisoning the land and sea is not the path to it, rather than dismissing the aspiration.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Objection in the consultation.

Subject: Objection — [project] near [place].

"We, residents of [place], object to [project]: [its radioactive dust and waste, its threat to our land-and-sea livelihoods, in a fragile Arctic]. We ask that it be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8B — Raising the livelihood case (to the public / Naalakkersuisut).

Subject: Our land and sea, and [project].

"We, the community of [place], depend on the land and sea [project] would poison: [specifics]. We ask that our livelihoods be protected. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Making it the ballot question (to the coalition / public).

Subject: Let this project be the nation's decision.

"We, [group], call on Greenlanders to make [project] the question at the polls, as Narsaq did with Kvanefjeld, and to elect those who will stop it. [Contact.]"

8D — Toward legislation (to members of the Inatsisartut).

Subject: A law to close [project].

"We ask the Inatsisartut to change the law to close [project] — as the 2021 uranium ban closed Kvanefjeld: [specifics]. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — Court challenge (to a lawyer).

Subject: Flawed process / approval — [project].

"We submit that the [consultation / environmental process / approval] for [project] is flawed: [specifics]. We ask your advice on a challenge in the courts. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the company.

Subject: Opposition and risk — [project].

"We are the community affected by [project] near [place], which threatens our land and sea. It faces sustained democratic opposition and possible legislative closure, as at Kvanefjeld. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: A town of a thousand faces a uranium mine the world wants.

"[Project], a [rare-earth/uranium] mine near [place], threatens the land and sea we live by. We can provide the risk, the livelihood stake, and the community's voice. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the nation.

Subject: Our land, our sea, our decision.

"[Project] would poison the land and sea we depend on. At Narsaq, a town of a thousand made a mine the nation's decision and closed it with a law. Let's make this our decision too. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Root everything in the land-and-sea livelihoods — the unifying stake (8B).**
2. **Document the radioactive and environmental risk.**
3. **Object in the consultation (8A).**
4. **Make the project the country's ballot question (8C).**
5. **Push for a law through the Inatsisartut to close it (8D).**
6. **Go national and international, and build to reverse the current (8G/8H).**

Even lean, those six make a project the country's decision and change the law — the Kvanefjeld template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Greenland's self-government is a strong lever, but the current runs for big projects, and you must plan for it.

When the independence-and-money current runs for the project. Expect it — mining revenue is seen as the path to freedom from the Danish grant. Go with the grain of the aspiration, not against it: argue that poisoning the land and sea is not the path to independence, and build the case and coalition to reverse an established policy, as Narsaq did.

When the geopolitics are large. Rare earths draw China, the US, and Europe. A local decision can face pressures far larger than the fjord; lean on the democratic and legislative power that is genuinely Greenland's own.

When the company pursues arbitration. The company may pursue a billion-dollar investor-state claim against the government. That falls on the government, not the community; don't let the threat deter the democratic fight, and support the government in resisting it.

When you must go against the current. The anti-uranium win reversed the establishment's own policy. Build the mobilisation and the coalition to win an election and change a law — the decisive Greenlandic path.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Greenland is a functioning democracy, but the closeness of foreign mining money to a small political system, and the pull of the independence dream, create real risks of capture, so this matters.

How to spot it. Approvals against the environmental evidence; a process shaped for a favoured investor; the independence dream used to wave through harm; benefits to the connected while communities' land and sea bear the cost.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Greenland's audit and oversight bodies examine public money and conduct. The **Inatsisartut** and the **courts** can change the law and quash a flawed process. The **electorate** can turn out a captured government, as in 2021. And Greenland's **communities, press, and international allies** can expose a bad deal.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how a process was shaped, who benefits, what the environmental evidence shows — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the audit bodies, the courts, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back, and, above all, take it to the electorate. Pair the exposure with the democratic and legislative fight.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documented risk builds your case; the land-and-sea livelihoods unify it; the community and the public are the muscle; the consultation, the election, and the Inatsisartut press it; the courts and international attention reach it. Together they multiply. One at a time, or against an unreversed current, they stall.

Early on (weeks 1–8): document the radioactive and livelihood risk; root the fight in the land and sea; object in the consultation; build a coalition; read the current you face.

In the thick of it (election cycle): make the project the ballot question; win the public; elect a government that will stop it.

The long haul (months–year+): change the law through the Inatsisartut; resist the arbitration and the great-power pressure; hold the line for a project stopped, a livelihood defended, and a law changed.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Greenland can be done — a town of a thousand made a world-coveted uranium mine the nation's decision and closed it with a law. Hold both truths. Greenland's distinctive power is real: self-government at an intimate scale, where a self-ruling Arctic nation of some fifty-six thousand controls its own minerals through the Inatsisartut and the Naalakkersuisut, where a town of a thousand can shape a national election, and where the land-and-sea livelihoods bind a community to its cause. And the constraints are real: a standing pressure for big projects driven by the dream of economic independence from the Danish grant, a company that pursued a billion-dollar arbitration, and rare earths at the centre of a great-power contest.

Here's the discipline that wins. Root the fight in the land-and-sea livelihoods — the fishing, the farming, the harvest a radioactive mine would destroy — the stake that unifies a community and a nation. Document the radioactive dust and the environmental risk, object in the consultation, and use the courts against a flawed

process. Then make the project the country's decision, as Narsaq did — the ballot question, so a government that will stop it wins — and build toward a law through the Inatsisartut that closes it for good, as the 2021 uranium ban closed Kvanefjeld. Reckon honestly with the current you go against — the independence dream, the money, the geopolitics — and argue that poisoning the land and sea is not the path to freedom. Count a project stopped, a livelihood defended, and a law changed as wins. That's what Narsaq did — the democratic and legislative power of a self-governing people, at an intimate scale. So can you.